

AI Résumé Screening and the Limits of Rule-Based Fairness

Why Are We Talking About This Topic?

Hiring Built on Personal Contact

For a long time now, acquiring a job in Vietnam has been dependent on personal connections or face-to-face interactions. Although a résumé was important, it also matters whether a hiring manager felt a sense of trust and passion after meeting an applicant in person or through an online interview. For years now, online interviews have been the most popular method to hire employees, because they allow recruiters to see applicants online or in person and have a one-on-one conversation.

However, this system of online interviews has been changing rapidly. To be more specific, according to recruitment firm Reeracoen Vietnam, over 70 percent of large enterprises in the country now use some form of automation and AI in hiring (Ong). The automated system has the ability to screen résumés and rank candidates before a human recruiter even opens a person's portfolio files. Another essential example comes from VietnamWorks, one of the largest job platforms in Vietnam, which uses an AI Screening feature that automatically ranks résumés by skills and experience ("Dùng VietnamWorks AI"; "VietnamWorks Launches New AI-Powered Features"). Because of its popularity, recruiters who once spent an average of nine minutes reading a single application can now have that sorting done automatically ("Dùng VietnamWorks AI").

A Divided Response

Views on the new screening system for hiring in Vietnam have proven to be mixed. On one hand, supporters claim that the new AI automation system saves time and might even reduce bias, since companies are now anonymizing details like age, gender, and photos during early screening with AI (Ong). On the other hand, some critics claim that if the AI is not designed well, the system may filter out qualified people, such as career switchers or young employees just because their résumé might not follow the usual formatting or if their stats might not be as impressive (Ong). For example, a talented young employee might be filtered out using the AI screening system because they might have less work experience compared to a senior worker. Consequently, the bigger question for this essay is: who gets to decide what a good résumé looks like, and can that decision maker be questioned?

Michel Foucault and Invisible Standards

Power That Operates Unnoticed

One compelling point of view directly is rooted in the philosophy of Michel Foucault, a philosopher who spent much of his career studying how power works in modern institutions. According to Foucault, power works the most efficiently when it is built into systems and routines without people being aware of it (Foucault 170-94). This is effective because people would stop noticing it is even a form of control and once the system feels normal, people would follow it without questioning the system.

In order to clarify Michel Foucault's ideas, Foucault is famous for writing about the panopticon, which is a prison design where guards can watch every prisoner without the prisoners knowing when they are being watched (Foucault 195-200). Because of this, many prisoners start disciplining themselves, because they can never be sure if a guard is observing their actions or not (Foucault 200-03).

Applicants Who Discipline Themselves

Therefore, when applying this idea to AI résumé screening, it reveals the problem with this hiring system. In particular, when a participant submits his or her application into the automated system, there will be an unseen AI screening system that judges a person's résumé based on standards that they were not informed about. Consequently, due to this lack of transparency, many applicants will start altering the way they describe their careers by using different presentation formats or removing minor details in hopes that they might be able to achieve a higher score. Foucault's philosophy warns us that when companies use an AI system to evaluate résumés, applicants will stop sharing their genuine experiences and cut out unconventional achievements in order to avoid getting flagged. As a result, talented applicants who do not conform to the system would be filtered out as well.

Aristotle and the Idea of Equity

Why General Rules Cannot Cover Every Case

Another important philosophy comes from the perspective of Aristotle, who wrote about the difference between following a rule exactly and actually being fair. In his studies, Aristotle points out that laws and rules are written in general terms because they have to apply to many different situations in advance (Aristotle, bk. 5, ch. 10). However, in real life, there are plenty of particular cases that a general set of rules or criteria cannot predict or handle. Based on this idea, Aristotle argues that fairness usually is about setting aside the strict letter of the rules and evaluating a person's situation before judgement. Aristotle calls this equity, and he believes it is important because rules cannot predict every case perfectly (Aristotle, bk. 5, ch. 10).

Extending this idea to hiring, equity can only be achieved through face-to-face human interaction. Understanding someone's potential comes down to hearing how they explain themselves and picking up on the little details that a criterion might miss.

What the Algorithm Cannot See

Consequently, using the philosophy of equity from Aristotle, when a company interviews someone online without the use of AI, it is usually to see if an applicant can handle questions under pressure, and whether they have passion for the job. Therefore, a mere online application that is evaluated by an AI system does not truly show the skills and passion of an applicant like an interview does. Additionally, a skillful human interview can notice a typo or awkward sentence and know that it does not deduct any value from the applicant. Conversely, an AI screening system not only cannot evaluate the passion and character of the applicant, but also applies the exact same rules to every single applicant. Consequently, incorrect formatting of the dates or a small typo might appear to the AI system as a red flag, resulting in the elimination of an applicant due to human errors. All in all, Aristotle's ideas warn us that the overdependence on AI screening systems might filter out talented and strong applicants while being incapable of actually measuring a person's competence for a position.

Counterpoint: Francis Bacon and the Idols of the Mind

Human Judgement as the Flawed Instrument

Although there might be clear downsides of relying on AI for hiring, a strong opposing argument comes from the philosophy of Francis Bacon. According to Bacon, human judgment is naturally corrupted by what he called the "idols of the mind," a set of mental habits that distort how people see the truth (Bacon, aph. 39-44). To be precise, Bacon believed that many people do not judge situations purely based on facts, but sometimes their conclusions get altered by personal mood or personal bias (Bacon, aph. 41-42).

An Algorithm Has No Mood

As a result, when applying this concept to AI résumé screening, Bacon's ideas suggest that the incorporation of AI would also result in the removal of factors such as personal bias and mood swings. This is due to the fact that the AI screening system relies on fixed criteria, meaning that it would stick to the programmed criteria without being subjected to personal bias. For example, a recruiter might unconsciously favor a candidate who reminds them of themselves or judge someone harshly because of a bad mood that day. In contrast, an algorithm has no mood and no instinct to favor anyone due to the lack of emotions. Overall, Bacon's philosophy suggests that AI screening might be capable of addressing a problem that was always there with traditional hiring. Since an AI has no emotional stake, there is no reason for twisting its judgment the way a biased human interviewer might.

Conclusion

Two Standards of Fairness

When viewing this idea from a wider scope, it is clear that there is a dilemma between algorithmic consistency and human equity. On one hand, thinkers like Michel Foucault and Aristotle warn that automated screening forces a person to edit their application to fit an invisible standard, which takes away the personal connection that true fairness requires (Foucault 195-200; Aristotle, bk. 5, ch. 10). Meanwhile, Francis Bacon argues that fair decisions happen when a person removes the personal moods and biases that disrupt human choices (Bacon, aph. 41-42).

Ultimately, whether an AI screening system is beneficial comes down to how a person defines a fair hiring decision. To be more specific, if a person interprets a fair hiring decision as something that is generated from evaluating an individual's passion for a position and face-to-face dialogue, then incorporating an AI system would be flawed. On the other hand, if a person defines a fair hiring decision as something that could be created through a strict criterion that is not affected by human favoritism, then the use of AI will still be relevant towards creating a fair hiring system.

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